

The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes, a collection of 12 [Sherlock Holmes](#) tales, previously published in monthly installments in *The Strand Magazine* between July 1891 and June 1892, written by [Sir Arthur Conan Doyle](#) and published in 1892. “To Sherlock Holmes she is always ‘the woman.’” So begins “A Scandal in Bohemia,” the first story in the collection. Irene Adler is “the” woman because she is the only person ever to have outwitted Holmes. The King of [Bohemia](#) fears that he will be blackmailed by Adler, his former lover, who has kept some compromising love letters and a photograph. However, she manages to turn the tables on the detective, retaining the photograph to ensure her own safety. Holmes, Conan Doyle tells us by way of narrator Dr. John Watson, has no emotional attachment to Adler, but in countless film and television [adaptations](#), such as the [BBC](#) series [Sherlock](#) (2010–2017), Adler is both a [femme fatale](#) and a decided love interest of the great detective’s. Other highlights in the collection are the eerie “The Red-Headed League,” where criminals offer a red-headed man employment copying entries from *Encyclopaedia Britannica* as a ruse to keep him occupied while they dig a tunnel from the cellar of his [premises](#) to a neighbouring bank. In “The Man with the Twisted Lip,” Holmes’s help is enlisted to solve the mystery of the disappearance of Mr. Neville St. Clair. His wife has seen him at the window of an opium den in a rougher part of town, but the police are unable to find anyone but a beggar. A number of [enigmas](#) follow before Holmes is able to reach a conclusion.